

Audit Preparation Companion

Example LLC

Calibration and test equipment laboratory based in Greenville, South Carolina, specializing in traceable calibrations for automotive and aerospace manufacturers.

Locale	en-US
Prepared for	Dana Whitfield
Companion to	Quality Management System Manual v1.0

This companion provides a structured set of auditor questions, evidence expectations, timing guidelines, and a readiness roadmap, tailored specifically to Example LLC's quality manual and processes. Use it as a practical reference to prepare for ISO 9001:2015 Stage 1 and Stage 2 audits — all questions, evidence, and timing points are adapted to your calibration business as described.

Context, Leadership & Planning

AUDITOR QUESTIONS

- ☐ You have set a target to reduce the certificate correction rate from 6 in 2025 to 2 or fewer per year by the end of 2026. Please show how this metric is tracked, presented to management, and who is responsible for follow-up when corrections are required.
- ☐ The manual references NIST-traceable calibrations for all disciplines. Can you explain how customer requirements for traceability and documentation are identified, communicated to technicians, and documented in issued certificates?
- ☐ What process is followed at Example LLC to identify and reassess risks, such as overdue reference standards or variation in technician procedures? Who is the risk owner for each, and how are actions documented?
- ☐ Can you show how interested parties — for example, ISO-certified automotive customers or external calibration suppliers — influence decision-making and quality objectives at Example LLC?
- ☐ How are roles and responsibilities set, documented, and communicated to the team? For example, how do Dana Whitfield, Marcus Bell, Theresa Nguyen, and Kevin Park coordinate their duties relating to calibration quality?

EVIDENCE REQUIRED

- ☐ Quality policy signed or approved by leadership, with current version and issue date visible.
- ☐ Table or records of quality objectives (certificate correction rate, on-time delivery, reference standard recalibration status), including actuals vs. targets and responsible owners (e.g., Marcus Bell, Dana Whitfield).
- ☐ Documented identification of stakeholders (e.g., customers, external calibration suppliers, employees), showing their requirements and how these are addressed in the QMS.
- ☐ Documented risk and opportunity register, showing recent assessments for: certificate errors, overdue reference standards, supplier delays, or non-uniform technician procedures, with owners assigned (e.g., Marcus Bell, Kevin Park).
- ☐ Organizational chart and/or current role descriptions clarifying allocation of quality duties across Dana Whitfield, Marcus Bell, Theresa Nguyen, Kevin Park, and bench technicians.

TIMING & FREQUENCY

- ☐ Quality policy and objectives: must be current, applicable to live QMS usage, and reviewed at least annually (or on significant change).
- ☐ Risk and opportunity review: minimum annually and on major process or resource changes.
- ☐ Records showing at least 3 months of tracked performance data before Stage 2 audit (correction rate, delivery performance, reference standard status).
- ☐ Retention of quality records: as per applicable US federal and South Carolina state requirements (and customer-specific requirements, if stricter).

PREPARATION ROADMAP

- ☐ Have the signed and dated quality policy, objectives, and current risk register readily accessible.
- ☐ Assign and document all named responsibilities (leadership, management, admin, technician, reference standard tracking) in writing and make sure everyone knows their own role as per the manual.
- ☐ Start recording actuals for each KPI — certificate corrections, on-time delivery, overdue standards — and gather at least quarterly trend data to show the QMS is operational before the audit.
- ☐ Check stakeholder and risk registers are up to date and reflect current suppliers, customers, and any recent business changes since the manual was drafted.

Operation & Process Control

AUDITOR QUESTIONS

- ☐ Walk me through a real calibration job from customer request to certificate issue and return — who performs each step (e.g., Theresa Nguyen, Marcus Bell), and what records are produced at each stage?
- ☐ Your manual highlights that every calibration must use NIST-traceable reference standards, with Kevin Park maintaining the tracking log. Can you demonstrate how the due dates, current status, and certificates for your reference standards are managed, including supplier interactions?
- ☐ How do you ensure no outdated calibration procedures or instructions are used at the bench or in the field? What is the process for updating methods, and who approves these changes?
- ☐ If a customer contacts you about a certificate error, what step-by-step actions are taken, what documentation is updated, and how do you decide if corrective action is needed?
- ☐ Which external calibration providers and shipping partners do you use for your standards, and how do you evaluate their performance each year?

EVIDENCE REQUIRED

- ☐ Real job records showing end-to-end workflow: customer request log, job intake form, scheduling, technician assignment by Marcus Bell, calibration records (digital + bench notes), certificate draft and final, shipment/tracking records.
- ☐ Reference standard tracking log maintained by Kevin Park, showing calibration intervals, upcoming due dates, proof of shipment to external provider, and returned certificates (current and past due statuses visible).
- ☐ Document control records: master list of procedures and calibration methods, version status, change history, and evidence of obsolete instructions being removed from point of use (e.g., only latest versions accessible in the lab).
- ☐ Completed corrective action records following customer complaints: complaint log by Theresa Nguyen, investigation by Marcus Bell and technician, corrected certificates, root cause review, and any documented corrective/preventive actions.
- ☐ Supplier evaluation records for accredited calibration providers and shipping carrier: evaluation forms or meeting notes showing quality, timeliness, follow-up on issues, and status (approved, under review, etc.).

TIMING & FREQUENCY

- ☐ Reference standard tracking log: runs continuously, reviewed at minimum monthly, and updated on every shipment/return event.
- ☐ Document control logs and master lists: must be live and reflect all versions in use. Evidence of at least 3 months' operation before Stage 2 audit is expected.
- ☐ Corrective action logs and complaint investigations: update as soon as a customer complaint or issue is received; recurring actions should be tracked from first occurrence through closure.
- ☐ Supplier evaluations: formally reviewed at least annually, and after any significant performance or delivery problem.
- ☐ Retention of job records and calibration certificates: minimum five years, or as required by national and customer contract requirements.

PREPARATION ROADMAP

- ☐ Maintain real, date-stamped records from live calibration jobs spanning at least the last 3 months (not just sample templates).
- ☐ Ensure reference standard status is up to date in the tracking log, with no overdue items at time of audit; supplier certificates should be matched to returned standards.
- ☐ Review document control procedures — confirm only most recent versions of operating instructions and calibration methods are accessible to staff (both lab and on-site).
- ☐ Keep a record of all customer complaints and how they were handled, with associated corrective actions logged and closed out where applicable.
- ☐ Compile most recent supplier evaluation for each external calibration provider and your shipping carrier; prepare to explain any “under review” or performance issues listed.

Performance Evaluation

AUDITOR QUESTIONS

- ☐ Describe how internal audits are conducted at Example LLC. Who was appointed as auditor for the last cycle, which areas were covered, and what types of findings or improvements resulted?
- ☐ You monitor certificate correction rates, on-time delivery, and overdue standards. Show how results are measured, analyzed, and discussed in management reviews, and what actions are triggered if targets are missed.
- ☐ If your internal audit or management review found patterns of delayed reference standard calibration, what steps would be taken, and how are these followed through to completion and communicated to the team?
- ☐ Please provide examples of improvement opportunities or lessons learned that have led to procedural or training changes in the last year.

EVIDENCE REQUIRED

- ☐ Internal audit plan, showing annual schedule, selected auditor(s) (showing independence from the process being audited), areas covered (calibration job files, standard tracking, document control, etc.), and checklists used.
- ☐ Recent internal audit report(s) with dated findings, classification of nonconformities, and evidence of follow-up and closure.
- ☐ Management review minutes/records: including analysis of quality objective results (certificate correction rate, delivery, standards overdue), complaints, audit results, supplier reliability — with assigned action items and decisions.
- ☐ Corrective and preventive action logs: tracking progress of open items from internal audits or management reviews to closure.
- ☐ Documented evidence of completed improvements, such as updated procedures, new training modules, or briefings held in response to audit or review findings.

TIMING & FREQUENCY

- ☐ Internal audit: at least annually, covering all process areas (calibration records, standards, documents) over each audit cycle; must be completed before each management review.
- ☐ Management review: at least annually; should include actual data for each objective and a summary of audit findings, supplier evaluations, complaints, and open actions.
- ☐ Corrective and preventive action logs: updated as issues arise, not less than quarterly in practice, with closure documented before next review or Stage 2 audit.
- ☐ Evidence of QMS operation for at least 3 months before Stage 2 audit is normally required.

PREPARATION ROADMAP

- ☐ Assign an independent auditor (not involved in daily workflow) and conduct a documented internal audit of all calibration, documentation, and support processes at least once before Stage 2.
- ☐ Schedule the first formal management review: assemble KPIs, complaints, supplier evaluations, internal audit reports, and document actions and decisions reached.
- ☐ Keep evidence of all open and resolved corrective or preventive actions arising from audits or reviews, noting who is responsible and when closure happened.
- ☐ Track and document any improvements, changes to procedures, or new training modules initiated based on process data, audit findings, or feedback from the team or customers.

Improvement & Corrective Action

AUDITOR QUESTIONS

- ☐ What procedure is followed when a recurring problem is identified, such as repeated certificate errors or a supplier failing to return reference standards on time? How do Marcus Bell or Dana Whitfield initiate and track corrective action?
- ☐ Give an example of a recent improvement or corrective action resulting in a documented process or training change at Example LLC — what triggered it and how was its effectiveness verified?
- ☐ How are corrections or improvements communicated to technicians and administrative staff? What evidence can you show to confirm everyone understood and implemented the change?

EVIDENCE REQUIRED

- ☐ Completed corrective/preventive action records: problem description, investigation notes, assigned owner (e.g., Marcus Bell), actions taken, verification of closure.
- ☐ Evidence of communication to team: briefing notes, sign-in sheets, emails, or training records indicating who was informed and when.
- ☐ Before/after versions of documents or process instructions that have been updated as a result of corrective or improvement actions.
- ☐ Any evidence showing follow-up verification that the improvement was effective (e.g., a reduction in certificate corrections after procedural change, technician feedback collected).

TIMING & FREQUENCY

- ☐ Corrective/improvement actions must be logged promptly on detection of recurring/nonconforming issues. Track progress until closure is confirmed, and review at subsequent management reviews.
- ☐ Communicate and train affected staff on any process or procedural changes before new methods take effect, and confirm understanding (attendance or sign-off recommended).
- ☐ Retain corrective action and improvement records as per quality record retention rules (at least 5 years, or as required by legislation or customer contracts).

PREPARATION ROADMAP

- ☐ Set up a corrective/preventive action log and document all ongoing or recently closed cases. Assign responsibility and set target and closure dates for each.
- ☐ Collect and file evidence of communication to all affected staff after each change (e.g., copy of briefing, update email, signed attendance list for a training session).
- ☐ Ensure before-and-after versions of updated documents are kept for reference and differentiate the changes made as part of improvement follow-up.
- ☐ Monitor for effectiveness of implemented improvements by reviewing KPIs and technician/user feedback after each significant change and document any lessons learned.